

THE WALTHAMSTOW TRAGEDY.

STATEMENT OF THE PRISONER.

Mr. C. C. Lewis, the coroner for the Southern Division of Essex, held an inquest yesterday afternoon, at the Board Room of the Walthamstow Cemetery, on the bodies of the five children—Charles, aged three years and a half, Herbert, aged two years and a half, and Frederick, aged sixteen months, who were drowned, and two infant boys, aged seven days, unnamed, who were struck on the head with a hammer and killed by their father, William Gouldstone, on Wednesday night last.

Inspector Craggs, of the N Division, watched the case on behalf of the Commissioners of Police.

The coroner, after the bodies of the children in the mortuary close by had been viewed, said they had met there to ascertain under what circumstances these five helpless infants came by their respective deaths. He had no doubt the evidence would disclose to them that the circumstances were of the most appalling and heartless character. But, revolting as those circumstances might be to their feelings, he would ask them to dismiss from their minds anything and everything they might either have heard or read relative to the case, and hoped that they would be governed entirely by such evidence as might be adduced before them.

Ada Hamilton, wife of William Hamilton, of 8, Courtenay-place, St. James-street, Walthamstow, who had been engaged to nurse Mrs. Gouldstone, repeated her evidence given at the Court-house on Thursday, and in reply to further questions stated that William Gouldstone was sorer at the time. After I saw the first child (Frederick) it was half an hour before I saw the other two. I did not see Gouldstone that morning before he went to work. I saw him the night previous at about six o'clock, at teatime. He had had a holiday Monday and Tuesday, and at noon on the latter day he seemed as if he had been crying. He was very fond of his children, but when the twins were born he turned. He said that it was a very large family, and he wished they were dead. Gouldstone had never lost a day since he had been at work where he was. He was very steady, and his wife said she had never seen him but once the worse for liquor. Since the twins were born he had not looked at them, and he would not have gone to see his wife had I not persuaded him to do so. Gouldstone earned 2s per week.

The next witness called was Emma Clarke, wife of James Clarke, a carpenter, of 8, Courtenay-place, St. James-street, Walthamstow, who said: My husband rented the house. William Gouldstone, his wife, and family had lodged with us eleven months. He was at that time quite a stranger to me. He was generally a steady man. I only saw him the worse for drink once. He was a calm, placid man, and seemed to be very fond of his wife and kind to his three children. His wife was confined on Aug. 1, at half-past ten o'clock at night, her husband being at home. He seemed very strange when I told him of the birth of the twins, and he never spoke. The next night he was the worse for drink, but he made no noise and no remark about the children. Last Wednesday night, at about half-past five o'clock, I was in the back garden, hanging some clothes up, when the last witness, Mrs. Hamilton, called me. In consequence of this I ran up stairs as quick as I could. I went to the bed-room door, and found it fastened on the inside. I heard Mrs. Gouldstone say, "He has killed my babies." Her husband opened the door and said, "You can come in; it's all done." I entered the room and I stayed with Mrs. Gouldstone and the nurse. I saw the two babies lying on a pillow. They were breathing. Blood was flowing from their noses and mouths. Mrs. Hamilton covered them over with a sheet, and I went down stairs and called for the police, after which I returned to Mrs. Gouldstone's bed-room. Presently I went into the kitchen with Mrs. Hamilton, and saw the three little boys—Charles, Frederick, and Herbert—lying on the floor in the kitchen. They were in a row, and appeared to be dead. All their clothes were wet, as if immersed in water. Their hair was wet also. I saw Gouldstone arrested, but did not hear him make any observation.

By the jury: I have heard the mother say she wished the children dead—that was when she was worried.

By the Coroner: I did not think she was in earnest. She never said it in conversation. She had remarked it to the children when they worried her.

The coroner said he did not think anything would turn on that.

William Cheeseman, police-constable 36 N, stationed at Lea Bridge-road, said: On Wednesday afternoon last, at about twenty minutes to six o'clock, I was on duty at St. James-street, Walthamstow, when I received information that a man was killing his children at No. 8, Courtenay-place. Arriving at the house I went upstairs, and on the landing I saw William Gouldstone in the kitchen. He was in a stooping position over three children lying side by side on the floor. The three children appeared to be dead, and were thoroughly drenched with water. William Gouldstone had his coat and hat off, and had his shirt sleeves tucked up. As soon as he saw me he came towards the door and said, "Good evening, policeman. I have done it, now I am happy. I am ready for the rope." I cautioned him that whatever he said would be used in evidence against him. He then put on his coat and hat, and said, "Let me see my wife." I took him into the bed-room, and his wife said, "Oh, you wicked man! What have you done?" He said, "I have killed all your children. Now you'll be single again, and I shall be hanged." His wife said, "Have you any money?" He said, "Yes," and gave her all he had. He then kissed her and bade her good-bye. On the way to the police-station he said, "When I took my money last week I thought of buying a revolver to do it with, but I altered my mind, as I thought it would make too much noise. I had a hard job with the two eldest, but the little one I soon settled. I thought it was getting too hot. I have had five children in about three years and a half, so I thought I would put a stop to it." At the police-station he said, "I've done it like a man," and when he was charged—the charge being read over to him by the inspector—with having murdered these three children, he said, "Quite right, sir." The hammer produced I received from Mrs. Hamilton.

The inquiry was then adjourned, and after Mr. Lewis had made out the orders for the burials of the children he, with some of the jurymen, proceeded to view the premises where the sad affair occurred.